

RATATOSK



Brian Suskind

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Press





CREDITS

DESIGNER

Brian Suskind

EDITORS

Scott Gable and Jeff Quick

COVER ARTIST

Florian Stitz

INTERIOR ARTISTS

Florian Stitz, Egil Thompson

LAYOUT

Marc Radle

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CELESTIAL GOSSIPS

Sálve, my friends! It is I, Lucano Volpe. A patrician of the city of Moredo and an explorer of modest fame. After returning from a sojourn to the Brilliant East, I did have the occasion to step from Midgard onto Yggdrasil itself and there met the curious squirrel-folk who inhabit the twisting branches. Herein, and with following missives, I shall relate distinctly what I beheld, and what I heard from trusted others, concerning the ratatosk.

—Lucano Volpe

Inspired by Norse mythology, specifically the *Poetic Edda*, the ratatosk are celestial humanoid squirrels who dwell in the extraplanar environment of the World Tree. Ratatosk are insatiable gossips and tricksters whose joy in gathering secrets is only

eclipsed by their delight in spreading those gathered morsels of gossip in mischievous ways.

The squirrel-folk build fortified towers and sprawling tree cities in secret nooks or suspended beneath the vast branches of Yggdrasil. In most squirrel-folk communities, 70% of the population is the tiny-sized ekorre (or ratatosk, see *Tome of Beasts*) and 25% are their larger cousins, the tradvakt (or ratatosk warlord, see *Creature Codex*). The last 5% are of a few lesser subraces, but these are seldom seen by outsiders.

In the byways of Yggdrasil, ratatosk often act as guides, leading planar travelers, though it is not uncommon to find squirrel-folk offering their services as couriers, thieves, or even spies. The tradvakt do not possess the planar connection of the ekorre, so they prefer using their martial skills to guard the ratatosk communities or provide protection for travelers.

RATATOSK THE CLEVER

The squirrel-folk believe they descend from Ratatosk, the first of their kind and namesake of their race. According to the myths, the wily and sly Ratatosk stole the World Tree seed from the gods and buried it at the very center of the multiverse where it grew large enough to hold the various planes in its branches.

For much of the early ages of the world, Ratatosk ran up and down Yggdrasil, carrying messages and insults between Nidhogg, the serpent gnawing at the tree's roots, and the mighty eagle perched upon the highest branch. From time to time, the clever squirrel acted as messenger for the gods, but he rarely delivered a missive unembellished. Even today, some of the gods show great reluctance in entrusting messages with his descendants while others think it provides great comedy. The squirrel-folk continue to honor Ratatosk with an almost deific fervor.

CELESTIAL GOSSIPS

The incessant chattering of the ratatosk is not mere animalistic nattering; it is a complex web of interconnected messages relayed from squirrel-folk to squirrel-folk. Their ability to use the message spell at will provides the core of this celestial gossip network. As described in the infamous *Nine Chthonic Papuri of Heknusret the Temerarious* (see *Warlock 9: World Tree*), the ratatosk visit the eagle at the top of the World Tree each day to exchange the latest news, rumors, and scuttlebutt. These tidbits flow from ratatosk to ratatosk and from them to the eagle itself in a never-ending cycle of gossip. Any traveler who wishes to learn the latest goings-on needs but ask a ratatosk. However, the little creatures cannot help but elaborate their news to make the stories better for their audience. This even extends to two listeners standing side by side. Each might hear vastly different accounts from the same ratatosk, which often leads to arguments, misunderstands, and even fighting.

ROLE IN A CAMPAIGN

Ratatosk are divine figures who dwell on Yggdrasil itself, so their traditional role of messenger or guide seemingly takes on a divine countenance. They can act as the focus of a quest—perhaps a tidbit of information needed by the heroes is known to a particular ratatosk—or as is often the case, perhaps a ratatosk went just a bit too far and shared the wrong bit of gossip with the wrong person and now needs rescue. The squirrel-folk can appear at the end of a quest as well. After defeating a major foe, perhaps a

ratatosk appears to deliver important information from a divine patron or a well-deserved reward from a mysterious benefactor.

If the GM needs a twist—or an amusing side story—the ratatosk can provide. Perhaps after the heroes learn some critical bit of information, a ratatosk arrives to convince them to share the lore. Of course, if denied, the ratatosk are not above nicking an importing looking scroll or item left unguarded.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

There are many stories to be told of the ratatosk:

- The great Library of Friula has a squirrel problem. Ratatosk raiders plague the stacks and halls of the library, stealing books and scrolls only to return them to the shelves altered with exaggerated facts and outright lies. Keeper Lynnean Verdia is desperate. Can the PCs delve into the endless stacks to stop this scurry of squirrel-folk before the entire library is hopelessly edited?
- An audacious ratatosk thief steals a scroll of forgotten wisdom from the wrong mark. With too many foes on her trail, the sly squirrel-folk hires the PCs to escort her to the Black Cyprus World Tree, west of Verrayne. Of course, she neglects to mention the scroll's owner is the Lord of Demon Mountain himself!

CULTURE AND SOCIETY

Following in the footsteps of Heknusret the Temerarious and his Nine Chthonic Papyri, I did spend a marvelous season among the Ratatosk of Yggdrasil. A curious and mischievous race, the squirrel-folk exhibit a carefree existence based on guiding travelers, collecting and spreading gossip, and feasting. Yet for all they delight in sharing the secrets of others, I suspect they harbor deep mysteries beneath their adorable exteriors.

—Lucano Volpe

RATATOSK CULTURE AND SOCIETY

Unlike the common Midgardian squirrel, ratatosk are not solitary creatures, and they live in close matriarchal family groups called scurries. The squirrel-folk are proud of their heritage, and each ratatosk can proudly recite tales of their scurry back to the first squirrel, Ratatosk the Clever. The eldest female of each scurry sits on a council, maintaining order and resolving disputes within their dray, or ratatosk settlement. Occasionally the council will appoint a warleader to lead a raid against a nearby threat, but its

most important duty is to host the sakmoot, a daily gathering (usually in the morning) where the ratatosk gather to exchange news and gossip. Information from across the planes filters down to the sakmoot. A common ratatosk adage states, “The softest whisper in the farthest nook of the endless void will eventually be repeated in the smallest sakmoot.”

There are no secrets for the ratatosk. The exchange of news and gossip is routine and expected between individuals, and indeed, no real business is ever conducted by a ratatosk before secrets are shared. Personal property is more of a vague guideline to the ratatosk rather than any established law. They think nothing of “borrowing” something shiny or interesting, which they fully intend to return if they do not get distracted.

Visitors to a dray may feel bombarded with intrusive questions from the ever-curious squirrel-folk. Older ratatosk try not to “borrow” items from non-ratatosk, but the younger members of a dray may not be so restrained.

RATATOSK SETTLEMENTS

Life in a ratatosk dray is a boisterous, chattering place, providing warm hearths, food, music, and stories to their friends—and death by a thousand sharp teeth to their enemies. The drays themselves are small affairs, consisting of a dozen scurries, and are hidden in scattered locations up and down the length of Yggdrasil. The tradvakt (ratatosk warlord, see *Creature Codex*) provide protection for each dray while the majority of the community is made up of the smaller ekorre (ratatosk, see *Tome of Beasts*) and a few members of other planar races.

Typical settlements consist of a few exterior, free-standing buildings fashioned out of discarded World Tree bark and tucked into the crook of two or more massive branches. These structures are cleverly camouflaged and require a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check to spot. A stout wall of woven vines and branches gives the squirrel-folk a protective barrier against the occasional monster or raider. The exterior buildings provide accommodations for visiting guests and a marketplace to trade. Beyond these structures, the squirrel-folk live in a network of halls, domiciles, burrows, storerooms, workshops, and public spaces carved out of the World Tree. They take great care to keep their tunnels within the outermost layer of Yggdrasil’s bark so as not to harm the great tree. Each dray has two buildings in common:

a feasting hall to host the sakmoot, and a temple or shrine dedicated to Ratatosk the Clever.

When ratatosk children reach adulthood, they exhibit a wanderlust few other races understand. Most simply explore Yggdrasil, gathering rumors and secrets from the Vedfolnir in the Eyrie, Nidhogg in the roots (see *Warlock 9: World Tree*) or those they encounter. Ratatosk often offer their services as guides to planar travelers, seeing it as an easy way to learn more gossip.

The largest ratatosk dray is Grenstad, home to 4,000 ratatosk and a smattering of aasimar, tieflings, ravenfolk, and planar humans. The city rests at the heart of the Great Branching, a union of five World Tree segments, and hosts the Squirrel Court of Yggdrasil, the Acorn Palace of Queen Clarahekkarina, as well as the famed Ekollon Halle feast hall (see *Warlock 9: World Tree* for more detail).

Another famous dray is Orypel. This magically hidden stronghold of 500 is situated near the Well of Urd and sends scouts who risk obliteration to spy upon the Norns. The Three Sisters are well aware of the ratatosk interlopers and occasionally use their eavesdropping to unofficially pass on information.



FOOD AND DRINK

Ratatosk are omnivores, though their diet is primarily vegetarian. The main foodstuff of the squirrel-folk is gryta, a rich nut stew made from the acorns of the World Tree and sweetened with honey and spices. They also eat berries and flower bulbs grown in vertical gardens set into Yggdrasil's trunk. Ratatosk love the sweets and foods of Midgard and often exchange goods or services for pies, candies, or sweetmeats.

BLESSED GRYTA MEAD

Potion, very rare

Enhanced by ratatosk brewer-clerics, this thick, golden liquid is brewed from the acorns of the World Tree and smells of honey and oak. When you drink a pint of this elixir, you gain the benefits of a *heroes' feast* spell for 1 hour. In addition, you have advantage on Dexterity checks and saving throws for the same duration.

HOLIDAY CELEBRATIONS AND RELIGION

Laugh at me all you want, you furry terrors! There is no way in the Eleven Hells that I am going to do that!

—Lucano Volpe at the Fallskarm Celebration

HOLIDAY CELEBRATIONS

The ratatosk are a joyful race who use any excuse to hold a celebration, party, or feast. Where other faiths, such as worshippers of Perun, have days honoring specific saints, every single day of the squirrel-folk seasonal calendar is marked by a holiday. The subjects of these holidays vary from obviously important to something akin to a thinly veiled excuse.

When you arrive in a ratatosk community, you will certainly be just in time for that day's celebration. The theme of the holiday could be:

RATATOSK CELEBRATIONS TABLE

d8	Reason for Celebration
1	An important historical anniversary
2	A particular hero or legend
3	The first day of the month
4	Fur Brushing Day
5	The arrival of visitors!
6	The last day of the month
7	A favorite food
8	Celebrating the color green

The squirrel-folk hold two important celebrations, apart from these daily holidays.

VISKARMOOT

On the first day of Harvest Tide, every squirrel-folk community sends their strongest or cleverest member to the Aerie at the top of the World Tree, to the den of the serpent at its roots, or out into the various planes. These seekers spend 4 months gathering the most important secrets they can ferret out. On the last day of Snowfall, they gather in Grenstad to publicly present their secrets to the Squirrel Court before returning home to great fanfare and celebration. Visitors, both mortal and divine, often attend the Sharing of Secrets to hear the ratatosk's stolen lore.

THE FALLSKARM CELEBRATION

Held during the first week of High Summer, the Fallskarm commemorates the infamous ratatosk heroine, Churr Scurida, who brought a vital cure (to a disease) from the top of Yggdrasil to a ratatosk community near the base by leaping off the World Tree. To honor her memory, participants in the Fallskarm don specially made, winged garments and hurl themselves from one of the highest ratatosk settlements. The individual who reaches the lowest point of Yggdrasil without crashing on branches or trunk, succumbing to aerial monsters, or tumbling into the void receive great fame among the ratatosk as well as a prize given by Queen Clarahekkarina. In the past, this prize has been rare magical items gathered from across the planes, but it is a widely acknowledged secret that the winner of the Fallskarm can instead request the answer to a single question from Vedfolnir, the all-seeing hawk at the top of Yggdrasil.

RELIGION

Though not an overly religious people, it would be impossible to discuss the ratatosk without presenting information about Ratatosk, the Squirrel God.

RATATOSK

Nut Bringer, Keeper of Gossip, Clever Lord of Secrets, Patron of Travelers and Ratatosk

DIVINE DOMAIN. Travel and Trickery (also the Keeper Domain, see *Warlock 23: Bearfolk*)

ALIGNMENT. Chaotic

FAVORED WEAPON. Dagger, spear

Ratatosk is the clever runner, mischievous trickster, and laughing messenger of Yggdrasil. Responsibilities, rules, and orders fall forgotten to the joy of new sights, gathering secrets, and spreading rumors.



The followers of the Squirrel God view secrets as a challenge to uncover and share. In a plane-spanning multiverse of the powerful and frightening, he is an unredeemable source of joy and humor.

The public face of the Nut Bringer is a human-sized ratatosk with tiny silver tusks and a golden horn protruding from his forehead. When he appears to his faithful, Ratatosk speaks telepathically in a whispering voice, brimming with suppressed laughter.

WORSHIPPERS

Ratatosk is worshipped by those who dwell upon Yggdrasil, some planar settlements, and in a few communities near the various World Trees on Midgard. Messengers and far travelers in the Northlands make offerings of cracked hazelnuts to the Squirrel God for luck on their journeys.

SYMBOLS AND BOOKS

Ratatosk's symbol is a Golden Acorn. His priests mostly pass his faith along via oral tales and songs, though an exiled ratatosk scholar in the Marketplace currently seeks to compile the teachings into a complete tome.

SHRINES AND PRIESTS

The most famous shrines of Ratatosk are the Chittering Temple in Grenstad and the Wellspring in Orypel. The Squirrel God's priesthood includes ratatosk, ravenfolk, as well as a smattering of catfolk.

MASKS

Perhaps for obvious reasons, few faiths lay claim to Ratatosk as a mask of their gods. Some humans claim he is a mask of Loki, but various omens suggest the northern trickster god violently disagrees. Those in the Southlands or regions to the east of the Dragon Empire often equate Ratatosk with Nakresh, the Monkey God, though this connection is tenuous at best. It is possible that Ratatosk has no masks associated with him.

OTHER FAITHS

Ratatosk is regarded with humorous exasperation by most faiths, yet his connection to Yggdrasil means they cannot ignore him completely. He is a great source of information and gossip, though few gods trust the Squirrel God to keep their secrets to himself.

Ratatosk has a close relationship with the Northern Gods, though most of them distrusts him, except for Odin. For it was Ratatosk who secretly dripped the juice of a stolen Golden Apple into the one-eyed god's mouth while he hung upon the World Tree.

WHAT RATATOSK DEMANDS

Gather choice rumors and whispers as you would the finest acorns. Spread your gathered tidbits to entertain and amuse yourself. Guide the lost and the wandering. Always respect mighty Yggdrasil.

PLANAR GUIDES AND SQUIRREL-FOLK NAMES

If you find yourself tramping about the planes, you could do far, far worse than having a Ratatosk guide by your side. Just be quick with the fee, or you might find yourself stranded someplace quite unpleasant.

—Lucano Volpe

In their obsessive search for new tidbits of gossip and secrets, the ratatosk travel the various routes between the planes, such as the World Tree, the Ever-River, Red Portals, shadow roads, catslide alleys, and similar transit points. Many squirrel-folk offer their services, leading parties of travelers between the planes. Ratatosk guides do not have a formal guild or organization, but the vast majority do adhere to certain unwritten rules:

- Clearly state the destination before departure.
- Get half-pay up front or a magically enforced promissory (usually backed by a *geas* spell)
- Use the quickest and safest route possible
- No “petting” the guide
- No squirrel jokes

Fees. There is no standard rate for a ratatosk guide, and the payment varies widely from guide to guide. While coin is nice, most ratatosk prefer to be paid with knowledge and secrets, preferably rare lore or juicy gossip. They also accept magical items or shiny things if those catch their attention.

Travel Time. Due to their almost instinctive knowledge of planar routes, and the wide information net they share, ratatosk guides greatly reduce the

GENERAL TRAVEL TIMES

World Tree	2–4 days
Ever-River/Shadow Roads	3–6 days
Portals	Instantaneous (though finding the nearest portal may take up to 5 days)

Numerous other routes exist to and from the planes. Only the gods (and perhaps the ratatosk) know them all.

time required to travel from plane to plane. Getting to a planar route may also take time, depending on where the ratatosk guide is encountered. Of course, conditions in the planes are never the same twice, so these travel times are approximations at best.

NOTABLE RATATOSK GUIDES

Alva Frostpaw. This fierce ratatosk lives in a den carved halfway up Wotan's Tree in Trollheim. Currently, she engages in a feud with the local ravenfolk population who roost in the World Tree. Alva disagrees with the ravenfolk who believe only those ready should be allowed to pass into the planes. The ratatosk will guide anyone who meets her fee of exotic beverages.

Chitata Sharpeye. A canny and worldly ratatosk warlord (see *Creature Codex*), Chitata is the leader of Scurry Scouts, a collective of some half-dozen ratatosk guides. This thriving business operates out of a small dwelling at the base of the Golden Bough, a World Tree located in the Uppermarket of Klingedesh, the Marketplace Plane. One of the few guides who accepts hard coins, his standard rate is 5 gp for passage from the Marketplace to Yggdrasil.

Keerthi Cleversong. An older ratatosk, Keerthi lives in an uneasy alliance with Ruomu, an awakened World Tree sapling in the far reaches of the Brilliant East. The living tree isn't overly keen on travelers scaling him; however Keerthi is adept at bribing the massive mulberry treant with fine poetry and song. Her fee is often musical in nature.

Lutalo Flitwhisker. This ratatosk warlord guards Mamiwata's Mangrove, a massive tree growing in the middle of the Selweyha River Delta in Lignas. He will allow access to groups of climbers in return for magic items of uncommon or greater rarity. Secretly, Lutalo acts as a spy for the Lady of Vipers.

Nanja Sandtooth. A ratatosk with pale fur, Nanja can be found most often at the Menatayni Oasis in the Crescent Desert. For a small fee of gaudy clothing, she guides travelers up the towering Palm of the Sheikh and onto Yggdrasil.

Orrin Bristletail. (See *Warlock 9: World Tree*.)

This ratatosk operates out of Grenstad, the largest squirrel-folk city and is most often encountered on the branches of Yggdrasil. He is an insatiable talker with a love of dates and sweets who accepts the same for his services.

RATATOSK NAMES

The naming conventions of the squirrel-folk put the emphasis on a forename given to a child at birth. The ratatosk make no differentiation between male and female names. Names tend to be short, but highly respected families occasionally add infixes like “-ee-” or “-ekke-” to create longer names. Ratatosk who dwell in other planes sometimes take regional names.

During the course of a lifetime, a ratatosk gains and loses a number of surnames, usually a descriptive title in the form of an adjective or verb followed by a noun, such as “bristletail,” “wisetooth,” or “sharpclaw.” Most often, a ratatosk chooses this changing surname themselves to commemorate an important milestone in their lives.

Forenames: Chiringa, Ekirp, Kerasil, Najuta, Orrin, Skirekkeret, Tiptup, Turorri

Surnames: Brightsong, Flitpaw, Jumptwig, Silentleaf

RATATOSK NAME GENERATOR

d10	Prefix	d10	Prefix
1	Chir-	6	Scu-
2	Ek-	7	Skir-
3	Ker-	8	Tip-
4	Naj-	9	Tosk-
5	Orr-	10	Tur-

d4	Infix	d4	Infix
1	-ata	3	-ekke-
2	-ee-	4	-itta-

d10	Suffix	d10	Suffix
1	-asil	6	-rin
2	-et	7	-rrup
3	-inga	8	-rry
4	-irp	9	-tup
5	-orri	10	-utta

SURNAME GENERATOR

d10	Prefix	d10	Prefix
1	Bright	6	Punch
2	Bristle	7	Sharp
3	Clever	8	Silent
4	Flit	9	True
5	Jump	10	Wise

d10	Prefix	d10	Prefix
1	Claw	6	Song
2	Eyes	7	Tail
3	Leaf	8	Twig
4	Moss	9	Tooth
5	Paw	10	Whisker

MAGICAL ITEMS AND EQUIPMENT OF THE SQUIRREL-FOLK

I hurled the enchanted acorn to the ground. There was a terrific flash of light and an odd popping sound, and the acorn was replaced by . . . an acorn. I looked at my Ratatosk companion and said, "So it's a nut that magically makes a nut?"

—Lucano Volpe

With the secrets and whispers of the planes at their disposal, the ratatosk are quite familiar with powerful magic. Indeed, those seeking a particular item often consult the ratatosk. Yet with a few exceptions, the squirrel-folk themselves rely more on their own cunning supported by single-use items. A few magic items common to the ratatosk are described below.

CHAOS ACORN

Wondrous item, very rare (requires attunement)

This acorn was harvested from a branch of the World Tree growing in a chaotic area of the void. A sheen of ever-changing colors decorates its smooth surface.

You can use an action to eat the acorn. Doing so triggers a chaos magic surge. Roll percentile dice and consult the chaos magic surge table (see *Deep Magic*). If the result of the roll specifies a target, such as "the target of your spell or ability," then the effect targets a random creature you can see within 60 feet. The GM has final say on how the rolled result functions.

The chaos acorn appears in your pocket, whole and unconsumed, after a long rest.

CLOAK OF SQUIRRELS

Wondrous item, rare (requires attunement)

This wool brocade cloak features a repeating pattern of squirrel heads and tree branches. It has 3 charges and regains all charges daily at dawn.

While wearing this cloak, you can use an action to expend 1 charge to cast the *legion of rabid squirrels* spell (see *Deep Magic*). The swarm of squirrels uses the statistics of a swarm of poisonous snakes, except

that it has a climbing speed of 30 feet rather than a swimming speed. The swarm emerges from within the cloak and obeys your verbal commands for 1 minute before vanishing back inside the cloak.

FEATHER TOKEN: WORLD TREE SAPLING

Wondrous item, rare

This tiny object looks like a finger-sized tree sapling. You can use an action to touch it to an unoccupied space on the ground. The token disappears, and in its place, a tree sapling springs into existence. Though only 2 feet wide, the tree stretches impossibly high up into the sky. The sapling lasts 1 hour before crumbling away. When you begin climbing the tree, after 10 feet you *plane shift* to a random location on Yggdrasil.

GLIDECLOAK

Equipment

This finely woven cloak is fashioned from specially prepared Yggdrasil bark. You can loop your hands and feet into specially designed loops at the sides and bottom of the cloak to create a wing-like surface to facilitate gliding through the air.

While wearing a glidcloak and falling, you can use an action each turn to glide half of your falling speed in the horizontal direction of your choice. Before striking the ground, a successful DC 15 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check negates any falling damage. The glidcloak has no effect if the falling distance is less than 15 feet.

Cost: 200 gp



MIMWOOD ARMOR

Armor (medium or heavy, but not hide or chain), uncommon

Mimwood is a wood harvested from Yggdrasil and alchemically rendered as strong as steel. Armor made from mimwood is naturally resistant to fire but does not impart this resistance to the wearer.

NIDHOGG'S TOOTH

Wondrous Item, very rare

This fist-sized serpent's fang is carved from obsidian and is curiously cold to the touch.

You can use an action to place the fang in an unoccupied space within your reach or to throw it into an unoccupied space within 10 feet of you. Upon doing so, it burrows into the ground and vanishes. A tveirherjar (see *Creature Codex*) appears in an unoccupied space as close to where the fang vanished as possible. The tveirherjar is an ally to you, speaks all the languages you speak, and lingers for 10 rounds before disappearing.

SKIPSTONE

Wondrous Item, rare

This small bark-colored stone measures 3/4 of an inch in diameter and weighs an ounce. You can use an action to throw it up to 60 feet. The first creature struck by, or that physically touches, the stone within the next 1d4 rounds must succeed a DC 15 Constitution saving throw or be thrown forward 1 round in time. The creature disappears, during which time it cannot act or be acted upon in any way. When the creature returns, it is unaware that any time has passed. After the stone is used, it crumbles to dust.

YGGDRASIL NET

Weapon (net), uncommon

This net is a ranged weapon woven from living vines cultivated from those growing upon the side of the World Tree. It functions as a normal net except it has AC 10 and 10 hp. Creatures restrained by the net take 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage each round as the vines constrict. If the net is broken or cut apart, it heals 1d4 hit points each day at dawn as long as the remains of the net are kept in close proximity to each other. Magical healing functions normally on an Yggdrasil net.

SPELLS OF THE SQUIRREL-FOLK

Though they may not look it upon first glance, the ratatosk count clever and skillful spellcasters among their number. How could they not, living as they do in boughs of the World Tree? Still, as talented as their mages are, I confess that the squirrel-folk treat their spellcasting with the same level of flippancy as they do with all other aspects of life. Living among them is to be subjected to spell-caused pranks and jokes on a daily basis.

—Lucano Volpe

For the squirrel-folk, spells are spells. They do not bother limiting them to one class or another. The following spells are special to the ratatosk, and they only share them with those they trust. Spellcasters who learn a ratatosk spell must meet any level requirement. A ratatosk spell chosen by a spellcaster is considered to be a spell of the spellcaster's class.

CONJURE ACORNS

1st-level conjuration

CASTING TIME: 1 action

RANGE: 30 feet

COMPONENTS: V, S

DURATION: Instantaneous

You create 1 pound of acorns on the ground or in a container within range. The acorns spoil if uneaten after 24 hours.

GLIDE

Transmutation cantrip

CASTING TIME: 1 reaction, which you take when you or a creature within 60 feet of you falls

RANGE: 60 feet

COMPONENTS: V, M (an unbroken leaf)

DURATION: 1 minute

Choose 1 falling creature within range. A falling creature can move 5 feet horizontally for every 10 feet it falls vertically, up to a maximum distance equal to their normal speed.

GNAWING LEAP

1st-level evocation

CASTING TIME: 1 bonus action

RANGE: Self

COMPONENTS: S, M (the teeth in your mouth)

DURATION: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You surround yourself with spectral gnashing teeth and leap through the air up to half your normal speed. Your leap does not provoke opportunity attacks, and



you must land within 5 feet of a target. Upon landing, you can make a single melee attack against that target. On a hit, the target suffers your weapon's normal effects, and the attack deals an extra 1d6 piercing damage from the spectral teeth.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 2nd level or higher, the leap distance increases by 5 feet, and the extra damage dealt by the attack increases by 1d6 for each slot above 1st.

HOST OF DIMINUTIVE HUMANS

3rd-level conjuration

CASTING TIME: 1 action

RANGE: 60 feet

COMPONENTS: V, S, M (a stick figure of a human)

DURATION: Concentration, up to 1 minute

While in a settlement, you call a host of Tiny human-looking creatures to emerge from buildings, alleys, or sewers at a point you can see within range. The humans form into a swarm that uses the statistics of a swarm of poisonous snakes, except it has a speed of 40 feet and no swim speed. The host of humans is friendly to you and your companions. Roll initiative for the host, which has its own turns. The host of humans obeys your verbal commands (no action required by you). If you don't issue any commands to the host, it defends itself from hostile creatures but otherwise takes no actions. If you command it to move further than 60 feet from you, or when the spell ends, the host disperses back into the settlement.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 4th level or higher, the host's poison damage increases by 1d6 for each slot level above 3rd.

VOLPE'S NOTE. The ratatosk were less than pleased to learn of the *legion of rabid squirrels* spell, formulated I believe by the mages of Bemmea. This was their, admittedly petulant, response.

QUIVERING TAIL

2nd-level divination

CASTING TIME: 1 action

RANGE: Touch

COMPONENTS: V, S, M (a tuft of squirrel fur)

DURATION: Concentration, up to 1 hour

You touch a willing creature and bestow the ratatosk's innate twitchy senses. For the duration, the target can't be surprised. This spell immediately ends after the first time it is used to negate surprise.

SPEAR OF YGGDRASIL

2nd-level evocation

CASTING TIME: 1 action

RANGE: 60 feet

COMPONENTS: V, S

DURATION: Instantaneous

You call upon Yggdrasil's might, and a thick tree root bursts from the ground beneath a creature of your choice that you can see within range. The target must make a Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, the target takes 4d6 piercing damage and is restrained by being impaled on the root. A successful save deals half the damage and the target is not restrained.

An impaled creature can use an action to remove itself (or a creature it can reach) from the root, ending the restrained condition.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 3rd level or higher, you create an additional root that can strike another creature within 30 feet of the initial target, and the damage from each root increases by 1d6 for each slot level above 2nd.

SQUIRREL-FOLK ORGANIZATIONS

"Spies? What do you mean, spies? Yes, yes, I know what the word means! I was just unaware you needed spies ... what do you mean you also have monks?"

—Lucano Volpe

Though the ratatosk may seem to be carefree tree dwellers more concerned with their next celebration or game rather than any matters of importance, they all have their own needs and agendas.

Three ratatosk factions of note are listed below.

MADBRANCH CULT

Limbs of the World Tree reach into all of the planes of the multiverse, so it is not surprising that some of those extend into the Yawning Void of Ginnungagap. The Void taint spreads from these points of contact, shrouding the leaves in darkness and twisting the branches into ouroboros-like tangles. These areas also alter living creatures, and the ratatosk are no exception. Tainted squirrel-folk lose some small piece of themselves to Ginnungagap's mind-bending unreality and become convinced of the need to open more of Yggdrasil up to the hungry reach of the Void.

Leaders, Organization, and Goals. The Madbranch, also called the Cult of Lyssa, is made up of Void-tainted (see *Midgard Worldbook*) ratatosk and ratatosk warlords. The squirrel-folk afflicted

by this corruption usually manifest Void taint as mental conditions rather than physical ones, though fleshwarping is not unheard of. They hold secret rituals to call upon the Great Old Ones in whispered Void Speech. In general, the madbranchers work to open void portals in remote locations of the World Tree, so the Void taint can spread unnoticed. The cult works in secret, living among ratatosk communities and slowly spreading the Void's corruption through offers of power, infected dreams, and the lure of knowledge.

Individual madbranchers all gain some ability to channel Void Magic and are able to cast the *crushing curse* and *word of misfortune* cantrips (see *Deep Magic*). The few individuals who are liberated from the cult, without becoming hopelessly insane, and cleansed via greater restoration spells lose their ability to cast Void Magic.

Notable Members. Nullmistress Lighteater (CE ratatosk void speaker) runs the largest sect of the Cult of Lyssa from a hidden enclave within the ratatosk city of Grenstad. She works to subtly corrupt the members of the Squirrel Court. Grey Chiv (NE ratatosk warlord) wanders the length of the World Tree searching for new pools of Void, so he might nurture the corruption.

ORDER OF THE ACORN

The ratatosk monks of the Order of the Acorn seek to unlock the power inherent in the bond they share with the World Tree. While not religious in nature, the order does acknowledge the gods while venerating Yggdrasil itself. The order is run by a council of the oldest and most powerful monks, all of whom bear the title farfar (or grandfather), under the leadership of Master Aldsta. Members of the Order of the Acorn also believe it is their task to safeguard the World Tree no matter where it resides and as such are the bitter foes of the Madbranch Cult.

Joining the Order of the Acorn. Full membership in the Order of the Acorn is limited to ratatosk, though non-squirrel-folk can petition one of the farfars to become an umgas (or companion). Some farfars require petitioners to complete a quest (determined by the GM) or donate some needed relic or magic item.

Once your petition is accepted, the next time you gain an ability score improvement, you may choose to limit this bonus to a +1 increase to a single ability score (instead of the usual options), and in return gain 1 ki point and the War Chatter class feature (see below). If you have levels in another class that grants ki, these points stack. Otherwise, they function as a monk's ki points.

New Class Feature: War Chatter. As a bonus action, you can spend 1 ki point to utter the chittering battle cry of the ratatosk. Each foe within 15 feet that can hear you must succeed on a Charisma saving throw (DC 8 + your Charisma modifier + your proficiency bonus) or have disadvantage on all attack rolls until the start of your next turn.

SHADOWTAILS

This covert organization of elite ratatosk operatives uses the collected information commonly shared among the squirrel-folk to identify threats to the World Tree and eliminate them. Although knowledge of the Shadowtails as a group of spies is a poorly kept secret among the ratatosk, the organization's darker function is generally not known.

Leaders, Organization, and Goals. Shadowtails operate under the direct supervision of Queen Clarahekkarina and make use of a large variety of magical items to aid them in their assignments. Within the Shadowtails are two main factions. The seekers are their "eyes" and excel in covert insertions, information gathering, and subterfuge. They venture into other planes to spy on potential threats. When threats to Yggdrasil are identified, the seekers turn the operation over to the hunters. The hunters embody the "teeth" of the organization and hunt down or assassinate the threats pinpointed by the seekers. Their preferred method is to use stealth and poison to avoid outright combat as this allows them to eliminate foes far more powerful than themselves.

Notable Members. Master Vrip (CG ratatosk) runs the shadowtails on behalf of the queen. The success of the organization is largely due to his leadership, though he has failed to realize his beloved wife Slarra is secretly the leader of the Madbranch Cult.

SQUIRREL-FOLK OF MIDGARD

It is quite simple to spot a ratatosk living in Midgard. If you see a squirrel, ask yourself one of these questions. Is it wearing armor? Jewelry? Is it carrying a weapon or a wand? Is the fur of its tail braided in beautiful patterns? Is it stealing some object of value from you? If the answers to any of these questions is yes, then it is a ratatosk and not a squirrel.

—Lucano Volpe

Few in number, the ratatosk dwelling on Midgard represent some of the best (and worst) of their race. Some are traditional and guard World Trees or guide travelers. Others disdain the expected role society thrusts upon them and seek to forge their own paths.



ALVA FROSTPAW

Obsessive olfactory collector

Background. This fierce ratatosk lives among the branches of Wotan's Tree in Trollheim where she regularly feuds with the local ravenfolk population. Alva guides anyone to Yggdrasil who meets her fee of exotic beverages, yet she is a collector, not an imbibor, and dislikes the taste of alcohol. Alva's love is the scent of beverages, the stranger the better. She keeps her "hoard" in her fortified den carved halfway up the World Tree.

Stats. Use ratatosk (see *Tome of Beasts*) but add the following new action:

- **Intoxicating Flask (Recharge 5–6).** Alva throws a flask of volatile liquor at a point within 30 feet. The flask explodes in a 15-foot radius. Creatures in the area must succeed on a DC 14 Dexterity saving throw or take 24 (7d6) poison damage and be poisoned for 1 minute. On a successful save, they take half damage and are not poisoned. A poisoned creature repeats the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the poisoned condition on a success.

CHURRIT THE DESTROYER

Arrogant bully

Background. Churrit the Destroyer always insists that his whole name be used when addressing him. As one of Beloved Leader Braagezz's enforcers, the ratatosk warlord occupies a favored position among the goblins of the Wasted West. Whispers suggest Churrit led Braagezz to the Ankeshelian vault where she acquired her ancient technology.

Stats. Use ratatosk warlord (see *Creature Codex*) but add a custom Ankeshelian disruptor (see *Warlock 10: Magocracies*).

- **Disruptor (Recharges 5–6).** *Ranged Weapon*
Attack: +7 to hit, range 100/300 ft., one target. Hit: 27 (6d8) force damage and all creatures within 10 feet of impact (including the target) must succeed on a DC 13 Strength saving throw or fall prone.

KEERTHI CLEVERSONG

Contemplative martial artist

Background. Keerthi lives in an uneasy alliance with Ruomu, an awakened World Tree sapling in the far reaches of the Brilliant East. She bribes the massive mulberry treant with fine poetry and song to allow travelers access. The silver furred squirrel-folk follows the teachings of the Eastern philosopher Laoshi and his "Five Steps" to enlightenment.

Stats. Use ratatosk (see *Tome of Beasts*) but add the following: Keerthi has 2 ki points that she regains when she takes a short or long rest. These points power her martial art abilities.

- **Flowing Dragon Strike (1 ki point).** As part of a successful gore attack, Keerthi forgoes the normal damage and effect of the gore to instead deal 14 (4d6) of a damage type of her choice (acid, cold, fire, lightning, or poison).
- **Locust Avoids the Sparrow (1 ki point).** As a bonus action, Keerthi spends 1 ki point to become more elusive until the start of her next turn. When an enemy targets Keerthi with an attack while she is elusive, she can move up to 10 feet. If this movement takes Keerthi out of range of the attack, the attack misses. This movement doesn't provoke opportunity attacks.

LUTALO FLITWHISKER

Spy for the serpent queen

Background. Lutalo guards Mamiwata's Mangrove, a massive tree growing in the middle of the Selwheyha River Delta in Lignas. He will allow access to groups of climbers in return for magic items of uncommon or greater rarity. Secretly, Lutalo acts as a spy for the Lady of Vipers.

Stats. Use ratatosk warlord but add resistance to poison damage and a *cape of the mountebank*.

NANJA SANDTOOTH

Sneakthief stylist

Background. A ratatosk with pale fur, Nanja can be found most often at the Menatayni Oasis in the Crescent Desert. For a small fee of gaudy clothing, she guides travelers up the towering Palm of the Sheikh and onto Yggdrasil. Nanja travels across Nuria Natal, sneaking into tombs to dress interred mummies in fashionable outfits from her collection. She believes she performs a much-needed service to the dead because, "they look so sad with their decayed clothing!"

Stats. Use ratatosk but add a burrow speed of 10 feet and proficiency with thieves' tools.

TURATUP FARSTEP

Devoted murderer

Background. Twisted and merciless, Turatup devotes himself to Karakhune the god of portals, otherwise known as Hune the Doorlord, by cleansing magical pathways with blood. He believes those who use magical portals and roads despoil Karakhune's

creation and must be punished. Occasionally he will trade his encyclopedic knowledge of magical portals and paths, but his price is high.

Stats. Use *ratatosk* but replace the normal spells with the following:

- At Will: *crushing curse** (2d6 damage), *knock*, *thaumaturgy*
 - 1/day each: *locate object*, *tree stride***
 - 3/day each: *dimensional shove**, *time step**
- (*) see *Deep Magic*
(**) this spell functions using doors instead of trees at the GM's discretion

THREE ADVENTURE SEEDS

How active are ratatosk on Midgard? Well, that's quite hard to say. What is one more squirrel among the hundreds or thousands our eyes disregard each day?

—Lucano Volpe

Listed below are but a few possibilities for adventures that feature the squirrel-folk.

A GREMLIN IN THE WORKS (BLOOD KINGDOM)

Sabotage rocks the construction site of the new Blood Cathedral to Marena in Varshava. Built upon the razed site of an older temple to Wotan, the new cathedral symbolizes the power of the Blood Kingdom. However, over the last month, an increasing rise of accidents and missing supplies has exploded into outright destruction and assassination. The hidden cause of the disruption is Yggdrasil's Thistle, a band of *ratatosk* hunting for a living World Tree seed located somewhere in the charred roots of the dead tree at the heart of Wotan's ruined temple.

HOW THE PCs GET INVOLVED

Aiding the Underground. By diverse means, the PCs receive a call for help from Vikkic Wavetail, a *ratatosk* of high renown. She begs the heroes to aid her friend Orrvr Toothchip in his sabotage activities at the Blood Cathedral and work with the *ratatosk* to recover the World Tree seed. Orrvr is one of the few survivors of the original attack on Wotan's temple and the burning of the World Tree. However, the scarred and nightmare plagued *ratatosk* hides a traitorous secret allegiance with the shadow fey.

Wotan's Revenge. The respected priestess of Wotan, Zosia Walerska, reaches out to the PCs, desperate to strike a blow against the followers of the Red Goddess

for desecrating the temple. She has learned of the sabotage of the Cathedral and wishes the heroes to secure an alliance with whomever is responsible.

THE STONE HEART HEIST (HIGH JUNGLES, SOUTHLANDS)

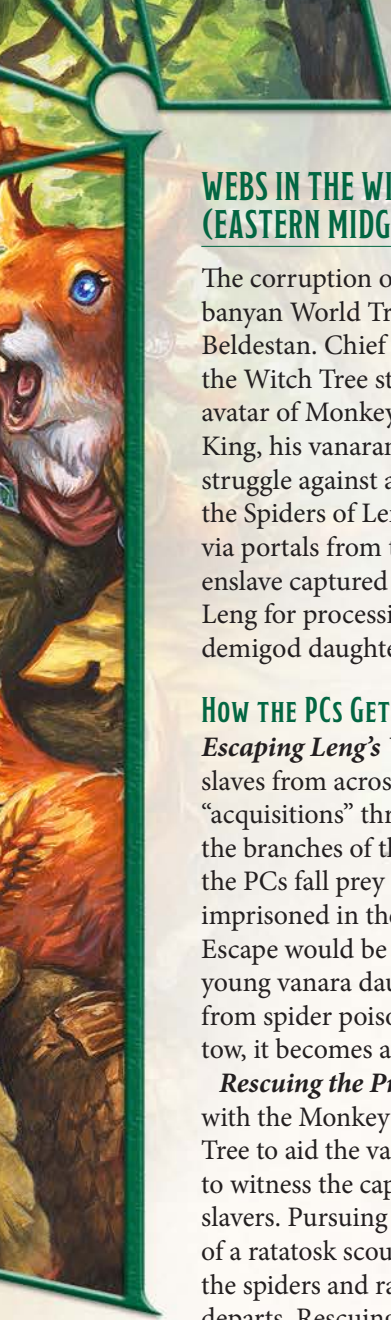
The race is on to recover the Lalob Key and unlock a treasure hidden within an ancient World Tree stump. The city of Nangui is a dark, wondrous city built around the *Stone Heart*, a petrified remnant of a once mighty World Tree. Deep within the stone-like tree, twisting organic passages lead to *Stone Heart*'s slumbering core. Here, ancient *ratatosk* hid one of their most precious treasures, Wotan's Tear. This legendary artifact, in the form of a shining golden acorn, absorbed the tears the one-eyed god shed while hanging from Yggdrasil, and is said to bestow divine wisdom. The first wrinkle is accessing the warren of passages within the *Stone Heart*, as it requires the Lalob Key, a druidic device lost during the rise of the Green Walker. The second wrinkle is that the PCs are not the only ones searching for the relic!

HOW THE PCs GET INVOLVED

Team Druid. Ufuoma Malangu, a Kushite druid, recruits the PCs to secure the Lalob Key from the dwarven ruins of Haldaheim. Once they have the key, they must slip through the defenses of the lich king, Nulu Nagoa, and enter the *Stone Heart*. Within the World Tree stump, ancient defenders and demonic invaders prove to be obstacles, but the greatest challenge comes from the two other groups trying to block the heroes at every turn.

Team Ratatosk. Nanja Sandtooth, or one of the other *ratatosk* on Midgard, hires the PCs to aid the squirrel-folk in recovering Wotan's Tear before it falls into the wrong hands. Their first task is to secure the Lalob Key from Haldaheim. Then they must brave the ancient defenders and demons within *Stone Heart* to reach the core of the petrified World Tree before the other two teams do.

Team Sorcerer. The immortal eye of Nulu Nagoa turns to the treasure resting in the World Tree stump beneath his palace. The PCs can earn a fabulous treasure in magic items from the lich king's treasury if they recover Wotan's Tear for Nulu Nagoa. First though, they must seize the Lalob Key from the vertical dungeon of Haldaheim and venture within the *Stone Heart*. Overcoming ancient defenders and demons could be tricky, but so too are the machinations of the other two teams racing for the prize!



WEBS IN THE WITCH TREE (EASTERN MIDGARD, BELDESTAN)

The corruption of Leng invades the massive, miles-tall banyan World Tree in the plains to the south of Beldestan. Chief among the diverse inhabitants of the Witch Tree stands the Monkey King, the earthly avatar of Monkey, the trickster god. The Monkey King, his vanaran followers, and their ratatosk allies struggle against a host of arachnid invaders sent from the Spiders of Leng, who arrived on the World Tree via portals from the forbidden plateau. The spiders enslave captured vanarans, transporting them back to Leng for processing. Recently, this included the young demigod daughter of the Monkey King!

HOW THE PCs GET INVOLVED

Escaping Leng's Web. Arachnid infiltrators gather slaves from across Midgard, transporting their "acquisitions" through portals to a new redoubt in the branches of the Witch Tree in Beldestan. When the PCs fall prey to the slavers, they find themselves imprisoned in the slave pits of the Spiders of Leng. Escape would be challenging enough, but with the young vanara daughter of the Monkey King dying from spider poison and an elderly ratatosk warlord in tow, it becomes a desperate race against time.

Rescuing the Princess. Contacted by a druid in league with the Monkey King, the PCs travel to the Witch Tree to aid the vanara against the Spiders of Leng, only to witness the capture of Princess Mejaa by arachnid slavers. Pursuing the captors, the heroes enlist the aid of a ratatosk scout to venture into the stronghold of the spiders and race to board a Leng voidship before it departs. Rescuing the young demigoddess may prove to be much easier than trying to pilot an organic voidship, plummeting toward the ground!

NEW SQUIRREL-FOLK VARIANTS

Consider, even the untrained ratatosk can hold their own in a conflict. Now, I want you to imagine a squirrel-folk trained to be an assassin.

—Lucano Volpe

With the knowledge of the planes quite literally at their claw-tips, it comes as no surprise that ratatosk have a wide variety of skills and abilities.

CITIZENS OF THE WORLD TREE

The ratatosk presented in the *Tome of Beasts* represents a squirrel-folk trained to travel the pathways of Yggdrasil and is the one most often encountered by PCs. However, a sizable portion of the ratatosk community is made of squirrel-folk who tend the fungus farms, run shops, craft items, or otherwise stay within the bounds of their villages.

Ratatosk Commoner

Tiny celestial, chaotic neutral

ARMOR CLASS 13

HIT POINTS 63 (18d4 + 18)

SPEED 20 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
4 (−3)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	15 (+2)

SAVING THROWS Wis +2, Cha +4

SKILLS Deception +4, Persuasion +4, Stealth +5

DAMAGE RESISTANCES bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical weapons

SENSES darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

LANGUAGES Celestial, Common; telepathy 100 ft.

CHALLENGE 2 (450 XP)

Innate Spellcasting. The ratatosk's spellcasting attribute is Charisma (save DC 14). They can innately cast the following spells without requiring material or somatic components:

- At will: *message*, *vicious mockery*
- 1/day: *mirror image*

Skitter. The ratatosk can take the Dash, Disengage, or Hide action as a bonus action on each of its turns.

ACTIONS

Gore. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) psychic damage, and the target must make a successful DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or be charmed for 1 round. While charmed in this way, the creature regards one randomly determined ally as a foe.

REACTIONS

Desperate Lies. A creature that can hear the ratatosk must make a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw when it attacks the ratatosk. If the saving throw fails, the creature still attacks, but it must choose a different target creature. An ally must be chosen if no other enemies are within the attack's reach or range. If no other target is in the attack's reach or range, the attack is still made (and ammunition or a spell slot is expended if appropriate), but it automatically misses and has no effect.

YGGDRASIL'S HIDDEN BLADE

Most hidden blades work in pairs and excel at infiltrating secure camps or structures, launching coordinated strikes at any who pose a threat to the World Tree. Others, however, break away from traditional ratatosk society and venture forth to make their way as hired killers. Hidden blade ratatosk typically have darker colorations either naturally or by the application of dyes distilled from acorns.

Ratatosk Assassin

Tiny celestial, chaotic neutral

ARMOR CLASS 14

HIT POINTS 63 (18d4 + 18)

SPEED 20 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
4 (–3)	18 (+4)	12 (+1)	17 (+3)	10 (+0)	18 (+4)

SAVING THROWS Wis +5, Cha +7

SKILLS Deception +7, Persuasion +7, Stealth +7

DAMAGE RESISTANCES bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical weapons

SENSES darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 10

LANGUAGES Celestial, Common; telepathy 100 ft.

CHALLENGE 5 (1,800 XP)

Evasion. The ratatosk assassin can nimbly dodge out of the way of certain area effects. When they are subjected to an effect that allows them to make a Dexterity saving throw to only take half damage, they instead take no damage if they succeed on the saving throw, and only half damage if they fail.

Innate Spellcasting. The ratatosk's spellcasting attribute is Charisma (save DC 14). They can innately cast the following spells without requiring material or somatic components:

- At will: *minor illusion*, *true strike*, *vicious mockery*
- 1/day each: *longstrider*, *silence*
- 3/day: *disguise self*

Pack Tactics. The ratatosk assassin has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one other ratatosk is within 5 feet of the creature and the other ratatosk is not incapacitated.

Skitter. The ratatosk can take the Dash, Disengage, or Hide action as a bonus action on each of their turns.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The ratatosk assassin makes two curved dagger attacks (melee or ranged) or one dagger attack and one gore attack.

Curved Dagger. *Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft or 20/60 ft., one target. *Hit:* 6 (1d4 + 4) piercing damage. The target must make a DC 14 Constitution saving throw. On a failed save, the target takes 10 (3d6) poison damage and is poisoned. On a successful saving throw, the target takes half as much and is not poisoned. A poisoned target may repeat the saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the condition on itself on a success.

Gore. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 piercing damage plus 14 (4d6) psychic damage.

Psychic Strike (recharge 5–6). The assassin delivers a quick slashing blow to the mind of a single creature within 30 feet. The target must make a DC 14 Charisma saving throw, taking 31 (9d6) psychic damage on a failed saving throw or half as much on a successful saving throw.

REACTIONS

Nimble Reposition. When a creature the ratatosk assassin can see hits them with an attack, the assassin can move up to their normal movement without provoking opportunity attacks.

WAY OF THE CLAWED ACORN

Utilizing secret techniques stolen from the Eastern Lands of Midgard, some ratatosk learn to harness the power of ki. The Clawed Acorn Order is a loose community of martial artists usually denoted by the braided headbands worn by members.

Ratatosk Monk

Tiny celestial, chaotic neutral

ARMOR CLASS 15 (unarmored defense)

HIT POINTS 87 (25d4 + 25)

SPEED 30 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
4 (–3)	18 (+4)	12 (+1)	17 (+3)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)

SAVING THROWS Wis +6, Cha +6

SKILLS Deception +6, Persuasion +6, Stealth +7

DAMAGE RESISTANCES bludgeoning, piercing, and



slashing damage from nonmagical weapons

SENSES darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 11

LANGUAGES Celestial, Common; telepathy 100 ft.

CHALLENGE 7 (2,900 XP)

Ki Power. The ratatosk monk has a pool of martial power represented by 4 ki points. These points can be spent to activate their Martial Maneuvers.

Martial Maneuver. Once per turn, when the ratatosk monk hits a target with their unarmed strike or gore attack, they can spend ki points to add one of the following effects to the attack. Unless indicated, each maneuver costs 1 ki point. Succeeding at the saving throw listed for a maneuver negates the effect but not the damage from the initial attack.

- **Apprehensive.** The target has disadvantage on all attack rolls until the start of the monk's next turn (DC 14 Charisma).
- **Confused.** The target is affected as if by a *confusion* spell until the start of the monk's next turn (DC 14 Wisdom).

- **Disarmed.** An object, weapon, or item held by the target is knocked 10 feet away (DC 14 Strength).
- **Knockdown.** The target falls prone (DC 14 Dexterity).
- **Stun (Costs 3 Ki Points).** The target is stunned until the start of the monk's next turn. (DC 14 Constitution)

Unarmored Defense. While the ratatosk monk is wearing no armor and wielding no shield, their AC includes their Wisdom modifier.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The ratatosk monk makes two unarmed attacks or one unarmed attack and one gore attack.

Unarmed Strike. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 bludgeoning damage plus 21 (6d6) psychic damage.

Gore. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 piercing damage plus 14 (4d6) psychic damage, and the target must make a successful DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or be charmed for 1 round. While charmed in this way, the creature regards one randomly determined ally as a foe.

REACTIONS

Kinetic Recovery. If the ratatosk monk begins a turn with no ki points and is hit with a melee or ranged weapon attack, the monk gains 1 ki point.

WORLD TREE BOUND WARLOCK

Many ratatosk believe Yggdrasil possesses a spirit, or a living energy, and worship it as a deity in its own right. Some, however, take this adoration further, fusing their souls to the World Tree with a binding pact. These fanatical squirrel-folk defend Yggdrasil from all threats, both actual and perceived.

Ratatosk Warlock

Tiny celestial, chaotic neutral

ARMOR CLASS 17 (Armor of Shadows)

HIT POINTS 63 (18d4 + 18)

SPEED 20 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
4 (−3)	18 (+4)	12 (+1)	17 (+3)	10 (+0)	18 (+4)

SAVING THROWS Wis +4, Cha +8

SKILLS Deception +8, Persuasion +8, Perception +4

DAMAGE RESISTANCES bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing damage from nonmagical weapons

SENSES darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14

LANGUAGES Celestial, Common; telepathy 100 ft.

CHALLENGE 10 (5,900 XP)

Innate Spellcasting. The ratatosk's spellcasting attribute is Charisma (save DC 14). It can innately cast the following spells without requiring material or somatic components:

- At will: *animal messenger*, *message*, *vicious mockery*
- 1/day each: *commune*, *mirror image*
- 3/day each: *sending*, *suggestion*

Invocations. The ratatosk warlock knows the following warlock invocations: agonizing blast, armor of shadows, mask of many faces, misty visions, and one with shadows.

Skitter. The ratatosk can take the Dash, Disengage, or Hide action as a bonus action on each of their turns.

Spellcasting. The ratatosk warlock is an 11th-level spellcaster. Their spellcasting attribute is Charisma (spell save DC 16, +8 to hit with spell attacks). They have two 5th-level spell slots, which they regain after finishing a short or long rest, and know the following warlock spells:

- Cantrips (at will): *eldritch blast*, *hobble**, *minor illusion*, *pummelstone**
- 1st level: *hellish rebuke*, *twist the skein**
- 2nd level: *hold person*, *thorn cage**
- 3rd level: *dispel magic*, *phase bolt**
- 4th level: *banishment*,
power word: *pain**
- 5th level: *hold monster*, *exsanguinate**

* see *Deep Magic*

ACTIONS

Gore. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 1 piercing damage plus 14 (4d6) psychic damage, and the target must make a successful DC 14 Wisdom saving throw or be charmed for 1 round. While charmed in this way, the creature regards one randomly determined ally as a foe.

Yggdrasil's Wrath (recharge 5–6). Up to six creatures within 60 feet that the ratatosk warlock can see must make DC 16 Dexterity saving throws as spear-like tree roots explode out of the ground beneath them. On a failure, the creature takes 28 (8d6) piercing damage and is restrained. On a success, the creature takes half as much damage and is not restrained. A restrained creature can use its action to make a DC 16 Strength check to free itself or another creature restrained by the roots.





WORLD TREE ENCOUNTER TABLES

Life here isn't all nuts and bushy tails.

—Lucano Volpe

The squirrel-folk relish living dangerously, risking life and limb as they traverse the World Tree in search of their precious gossip. The tables presented below describe some encounters the PCs may stumble across if they brave the environs of Yggdrasil.

YGGDRASIL CANOPY ENCOUNTERS

High in the all-encompassing reaches of the World Tree, the vast causeway of branch and bough stretch out to touch the farthest planes.

d10 Encounter	
1	Many a dancing foliage (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) force passing travelers to attend their year-long celebration.
2	A ratatosk runs up to deliver a summons from the Eagle in the Eyrie.
3	Two vine drakes (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) extort exorbitant tolls from travelers along a commonly used branch.
4	Squirrel-folk huddle in fear while an astral devourer (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) plagues their community.
5	In a sheltered bough, several oths (see <i>Creature Codex</i>) prepare a lengthy ritual to summon an avatar of Shoth.
6	A jotun (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) hangs inverted from a mighty branch, seeking to supplant Wotan.
7	A legendary item goes to whomever beats a thrill-seeking ratatosk at a wingsuit race.
8	A pod of void-touched ulnorya (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) hunt the upper branches, threatening all who pass.
9	Near the Eyrie, a two-headed eagle (see <i>Creature Codex</i>) permits access only to those with lore to share.
10	Spiders of Leng (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) hunt for workers to free their beached voidship in the branches.

YGGDRASIL TRUNK ENCOUNTERS

The vertical body of the mighty World Tree abounds with wooden tunnels, city-sized boles, and plateau-like growths where all manner of creatures cross paths.

d10 Encounter	
1	A war party of doom croaker ravenfolk (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) seeks to dislodge a new ratatosk settlement.
2	Several eldritch oozes (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) guard a newly opened portal to a chaotic portion of the Void.
3	Children of Yggdrasil (see <i>Creature Codex</i>) protect a sprig that may become a new Midgard World Tree.
4	The Magnificent Muck (see <i>Warlock 9: World Tree</i>), pulled up on a bank of the EverRiver, offers passage.
5	A party of kallikantzaros (see <i>Creature Codex</i>) work to cut down the World Tree.
6	Two ratatosk scouts spy on Baba Yaga's Hut, where it perches sideways on the trunk.
7	A forest emperor (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) demands travelers play esoteric games to use a convenient portal.
8	Seeking celestial honey, a bearfolk (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) explorer contends with giant honey bees (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>).
9	In a hidden bower, a young imperial dragon (see <i>Tome of Beasts 2</i>) guards a clutch of strange green eggs.
10	An ancient titan (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) of the Southlands sits in a hollow, juggling the divine sparks of his kin.

YGGDRASIL ROOTS ENCOUNTERS

The lowest reaches of the World Tree hide dangers and secrets in equal measures among the twisting roots.

d10 Encounter	
1	A misguided mead archon (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i> 2) plagues an innocent deathcap myconid (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) community.
2	A ratatosk agent needs to spy on a meeting between a folk of Leng (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) and the Norns.
3	A delegation of satarre (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i> 2) carries gifts for Nidhogg as they journey to the wyrm's lair.
4	The first Yggdrasil tosculi hive sends tosculi (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) scouts in search of an insectile relic.
5	The annual migration of millitaur s (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) threatens a new portal leading to the Arbonesse.
6	A band of einherjar (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) seeks sacrifices to entertain Nidhogg.
7	Fate eaters (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) kidnap a ratatosk elder to extract critical information from him.
8	Valkyries (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) guarding the Well of Urd seek aid against spawn of Nidhogg (see Warlock 9: World Tree).
9	A void dragon (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) offers a contest of wit to win the prize of a potted Yggdrasil sapling.
10	A party of shadow fey (see <i>Tome of Beasts</i>) use petrified treants to build a new portal to their dark realm.

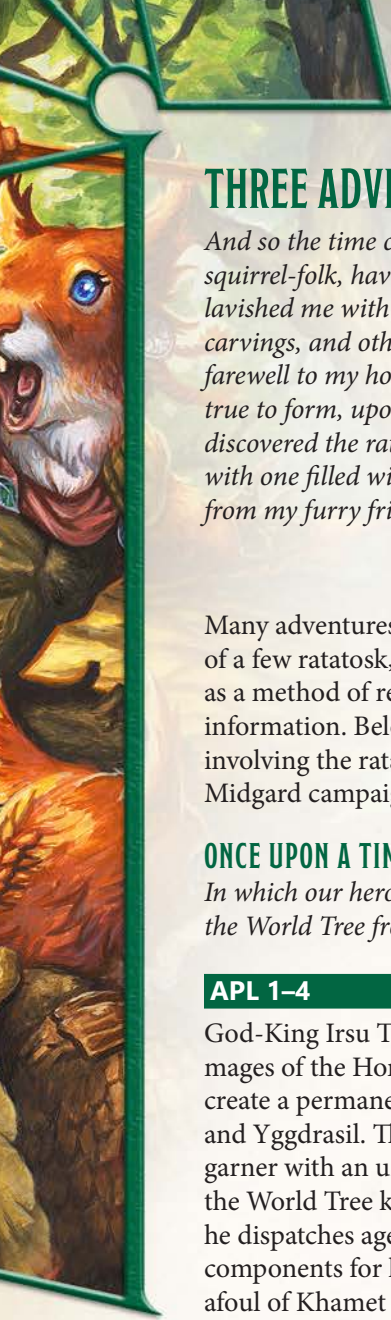
ODDITIES OF YGGDRASIL

Myriad are the trinkets and tokens found upon the World Tree, washed from the planes that nestle in Yggdrasil's branches.

d10 Encounter	
1	A worn and battered copy of the <i>Kobold Chapbook</i> , published in Zobeck.
2	An invitation allowing access to the annual Trespasser's Club Gala in the Marketplace.
3	A jar holding a viscous black fluid in which miniature ever-changing stars twinkle.



4	A silver crown decorated with imperial dragon scales and archon feathers.
5	The severed and rusted head of a clockwork humanoid, still ticking faintly.
6	A half-empty wooden cask of mead from Valhalla, marked with the sigil of the Storm Court.
7	A bone key which unlocks a sealed workshop in the Evermaw's Ossein Academy.
8	A glass orb containing a seemingly dormant sulfur rat from Urgennos in the Eleven Hells.
9	A carved ivory locket containing the dreams of a long-since deceased fey noble.
10	A humanoid drifts alone and seemingly lonely, forever searching for something forgotten.



THREE ADVENTURE PATHS

And so the time came to return to Midgard. The squirrel-folk, having grown fond of my presence, lavished me with gifts of food, strong drink, intricate carvings, and other treasures. With a heavy heart, I bid farewell to my hosts and began my journey. Somewhat true to form, upon reaching my home in Moredó, I discovered the ratatosk replaced my pack of fine shirts with one filled with leaves and acorns. One last prank from my furry friends.

—Lucano Volpe

Many adventures could benefit from the addition of a few ratatosk, either as a comedic side plot or as a method of relaying rumor, prophesy, or divine information. Below are three adventure paths involving the ratatosk and ready to be used in a Midgard campaign.

ONCE UPON A TIME ON YGGDRASIL

In which our heroes team up with the ratatosk to protect the World Tree from ambitious wizards and foul cultists.

APL 1–4

God-King Irsu Thanetsi Khamet seeks to use the mages of the Honorable Society of Portal Wizards to create a permanent Red Portal between Nuria Natal and Yggdrasil. The power and influence Khamet can garner with an unending supply of the rare flora of the World Tree knows no bounds. First, however, he dispatches agents far and wide to gather rare components for his Yggdrasil Door. Either running afoul of Khamet or acting to protect the World Tree, the PCs find themselves caught between ambitious portal wizards and ratatosk saboteurs.

APL 4–8

Nanja Sandtooth, ratatosk warden of the Menatayni Oasis, launches a bold plan to counter Khamet's schemes. She sends the PCs onto Yggdrasil to infiltrate a wizard encampment and replace a crucial component for the Yggdrasil Door. However, the Harbingers of the Yawning Void also have plans for the magical gateway, and their own cultists work to further the cult's ambitions. With no one to trust, the PCs must navigate a route to victory when open fighting breaks out.

APL 9–12

Despite setbacks engineered by the ratatosk, the Yggdrasil Door nears completion. The only hope to protect the World Tree lies in racing the cultists to a buried pyramid deep in the Crescent Desert and launching a desperate raid on God-King Khamet's burial place.

A FISTFUL OF RATATOSK

In which our heroes struggle to keep the machinations of revenge-seeking ratatosk from manipulating two competing factions into causing an all-out war in the free city of Salzbach.

APL 1–4

While fighting over a rare artifact, the Company of Lorekeepers and the Lords Arcane accidentally murdered an entire scurry of ratatosk. Seeking revenge, the relatives of the slain squirrel-folk launch a cunning plan to topple the entire city of Salzbach. The first stage in their scheme involves a series of attacks, assassinations, and sabotages designed to pit the Lorekeepers against the local Lords Arcane faction. The PCs enter the picture either as concerned witnesses or hired by one side or the other.

APL 5–8

With bodies piling up on either side, the ratatosk tighten the screws, secretly hiring the lawless free mercenaries in the city to launch open attacks on both sides. The city descends into armed conflict while the PCs work to uncover the true culprit behind the ongoing attacks, but the hatred on either side blinds the various factions of the city. One possible lead brings the heroes to a network of smuggler's caves outside the city, but the tunnels are one trap after another, engineered by the ratatosk.

APL 9–12

Civil war erupts in Salzbach with the abduction of both Guildmaster Swanne and Borin Hirsh-Dammung. The Lorekeepers, Lords Arcane, and the troops of the Hirsh-Dammung family fight pitched battles in the streets as the PCs investigate the kidnappings. The trail leads to the ratatosk lair where the squirrel-folk plan to sacrifice the two nobles to summon the avatar of an Old One to lay waste to the entire city.

THE GOOD, THE BAD, AND THE RATATOSK

In which our heroes aid three former friends—a naive minotaur, a disillusioned huginn, and an unstable ratatosk—on a quest for a fabulous lost treasure.

APL 1–4

Thirty years ago, three adventuring companions—Trarx the ratatosk, Zashul the minotaur, and Grima the huginn—managed the impossible: they stole an immense treasure from the lair of Ekbaris, an ancient gold dragon and contemporary of Mharot the Founder. However, before they could spend their loot, they were captured one by one and imprisoned. The treasure was never recovered. Recently, Ekbaris perished, and the PCs are recruited by Trarx, now possibly insane, to aid him in a daring quest. The treasure of Ekbaris rests in a portable hole, folded and hidden in a statue. The key to finding the statue rests in three parts, each possessed by one of the three former friends. The PCs must first brave the besieged city of Chamiras on Kyprion, use a forgotten portal into the Minotaur Labyrinth, and free the child-like Zashul.

APL 4–8

Together, Trarx and Zashul possess two thirds of the key needed to recover the lost treasure, but the final piece is known only to Grima. She resides in the Prison Pits of Voggoth. The PCs, and their two employers, must travel deep into the Dragon Empire, but their progress is not unnoticed. Jabbir, the faerie dragon spymaster, also seeks the treasure of Ekbaris for his master, the Great Lord Satarah, and sends assassins against the heroes.

APL 9–12

With all three former companions in tow, the PCs now learn the location of the statue hiding the treasure. Racing dragonkin assassins to the necropolis beneath the city of Efesis, the heroes brave undeath and draconic threats only to discover the statue was seized by the new sultan years ago and now, unfortunately, stands in the great hall of the Sultan's Palace in Harkesh. Can the PCs contend with the arguing and betrayal of the three old adventurers as they use a Midsummer's gala to infiltrate the very heart of the empire to filch a treasure from the claws of the dragon?

RATATOSK PC STATS

The following details provide everything needed to create ratatosk characters.

RATATOSK

Ratatosk are insatiable tricksters. Sharing gossip from across the planes, they delight in learning secrets and spreading those tidbits of information in mischievous ways. Resembling squirrels with sleek fur and small tusks, they form close matriarchal familial units called drays within larger communities called scurries. More adventurous ratatosk often act as planar guides and guardians, though it is not uncommon to find squirrel-folk offering their services as couriers, thieves, or even spies.

RATATOSK NAMES

The ratatosk make no differentiation between male and female names. These names tend to be short, but highly respected families occasionally add infixes like *-ee-* or *-ekke-* to create longer names. Ratatosk who dwell in other planes will sometimes take regional names.

Example Forenames: Chiringa, Daresh, Ekirp, Ekkitta, Kerasil, Najuta, Orrin, Skirekkeret, Tiptup, Turorri.

Example Surnames: Brightsong, Bristletooth, Flitpaw, Jumptwig, Silentleaf, Wisewhisker.

RATATOSK RACIAL TRAITS

Your ratatosk heritage is apparent in a variety of traits you share with other ratatosk.

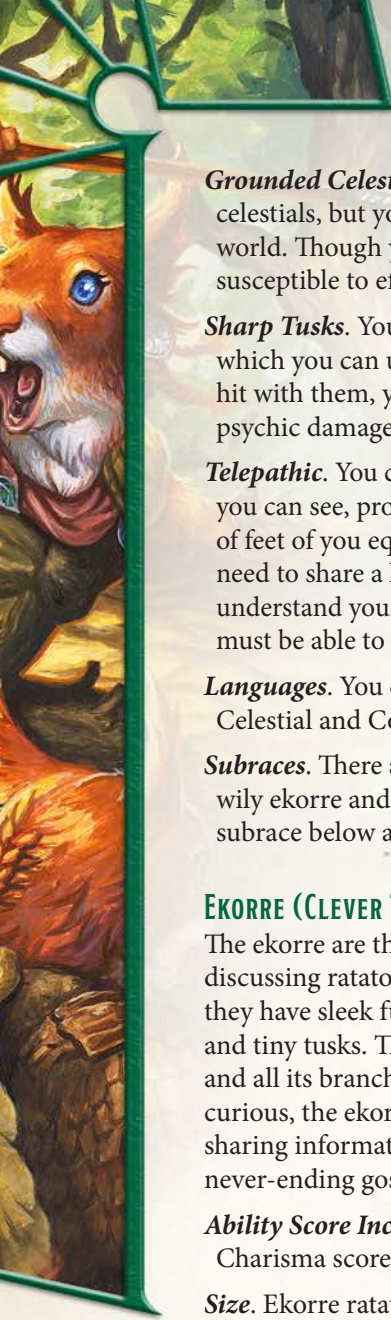
Ability Score Increase. Your Dexterity score increases by 2, but your Strength score decreases by 2.

Age. Ratatosk reach adulthood at age 10 and, due to their celestial nature, live up to 180 years.

Alignment. Ever curious and delighting in unpredictability, ekorre ratatosk gravitate toward chaotic alignments as they view laws as vague suggestions at best. The tradvakt tend to be slightly more focused and lawful in their thinking. Both groups tend toward good, placing value on doing the right thing, though some individuals lean more toward their darker impulses.

Speed. Your base walking speed is 25 feet, and you have a climb speed of 10 feet.

Darkvision. You can see in dim light within 60 feet of you as if it were bright light and in darkness as if it were dim light. You can't discern color in darkness, only shades of gray.



Grounded Celestial. You are descended from celestials, but you are strongly attuned to the mortal world. Though you are a humanoid, you are still susceptible to effects that target celestials.

Sharp Tusks. Your sharp tusks are natural weapons, which you can use to make unarmed strikes. If you hit with them, you deal 1 piercing damage plus 1d4 psychic damage.

Telepathic. You can speak telepathically to any creature you can see, provided the creature is within a number of feet of you equal to 10 times your level. You don't need to share a language with the creature for it to understand your telepathic utterances, but the creature must be able to understand at least one language.

Languages. You can understand, read, and write Celestial and Common, but you speak via Telepathy.

Subraces. There are two main ratatosk subraces. The wily ekorre and the brave tradvakt. Choose one subrace below and apply the listed traits.

EKORRE (CLEVER TUSK)

The ekorre are the image most have in mind when discussing ratatosk. Superficially similar to squirrels, they have sleek fur, often in shades of red and brown, and tiny tusks. These celestials dwell upon Yggdrasil and all its branches. Clever, egotistical, and endlessly curious, the ekorre carry messages across the planes, sharing information from individual to individual in a never-ending gossip network.

Ability Score Increase. Either your Intelligence or Charisma score increases by 1.

Size. Ekorre ratatosk are around 1-1/2 feet tall and weigh between 20 and 50 pounds. Your size is Tiny.

Blessing of Yggdrasil. You are attuned to the World Tree and can tap into its power. You know the *message* and *vicious mockery* cantrips. When you reach 5th level, you can cast the *mirror image* spell with this trait. Once you cast a non-cantrip spell with this trait, you can't do so again until you finish a long rest. Charisma is your spellcasting ability for these spells.

Diminutive Weapons. You can wield weapons with the light or finesse properties normally. You have disadvantage on attack rolls with other weapons, unable to use them effectively due to your Tiny size, and they are treated as two-handed weapons. You can't use heavy weapons at all. A weapon specifically designed for ratatosk (or for other Tiny creatures at the GM's discretion) are treated normally.

TRADVAKT (TREE PROTECTOR)

The tradvakt, also called ratatosk warlords, believe themselves to be the guardians and protectors of Yggdrasil and the branches of the World Tree. Larger than their ekorre cousins, the tradvakt train from a young age to master weapons and battle tactics. They act to maintain order in their communities and stamp out dangers that threaten those settlements.

Tradvakt who become adventurers do so for a wide variety of reasons. Some seek a more proactive way to combat evil before it can threaten the World Tree. Others simply wish to prove their martial skills. No matter the reason, tradvakt will rise to any challenge.

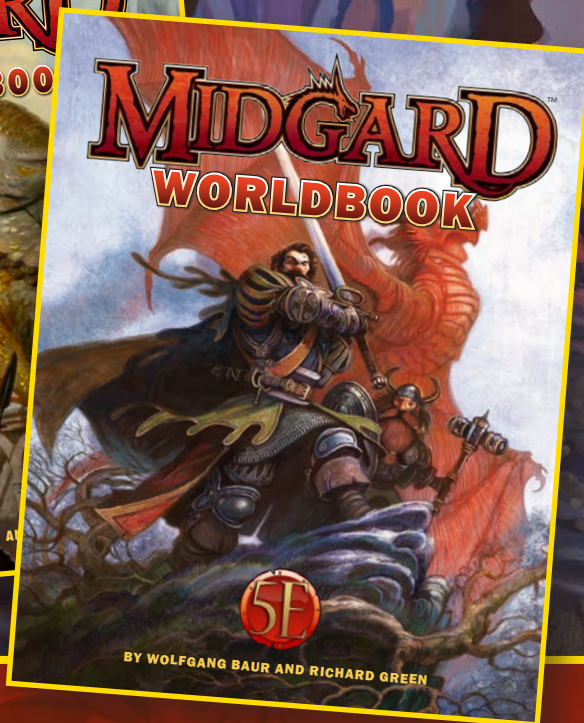
Ability Score Increase. Your Constitution score increases by 1.

Size. A typical tradvakt stands between 2 and 3 feet tall, weighing from 60 to 100 pounds. Some massive ratatosk warlords reach a towering 3-1/2 feet. Your size is Small.

War Chatter. Your constant chittering distracts your opponents. As a bonus action, a non-ratatosk creature within 30 feet that can hear you must succeed on a Charisma saving throw or have disadvantage on its attack rolls until the start of your next turn. The DC of the save equals 8 + your proficiency bonus + your Constitution bonus. Once you use this trait, you can't use it again until you finish a short or long rest.



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DISCOVER THE WORLD OF THE RATATOSK

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